

ANI



AWARE THAT THE BJP WAS MAKING STEADY INROADS INTO HIS STATE, THE BJD SUPREMO STARTED DEVISING SCHEMES WITH SPECIFIC VOTE BANKS, SUCH AS WOMEN AND YOUTH, IN MIND

other countries employed science in a big way, using advanced computers to study an athlete's performance and improve it," says Vineel Krishna, sports secretary as well as special secretary to the CM, who has overseen the transformation. "So, we have had them installed and, apart from sportspersons from Odisha, we have athletes and players from across the country come and use our facilities."

When it comes to the women in his state, Naveen has always been a champion at working towards their empowerment. In 2011, the state passed a law reserving 50 per cent of the seats for women in Panchayati Raj institutions. In 2018, he had the Odisha legislature pass a resolution reserving 33 per cent of the state's 21 Lok Sabha candidacies for women and making sure his party implemented it both for the 2019 and the ongoing 2024 elections. Mission Shakti, which began soon after he took over as CM in 2000, has seen a series of schemes being launched for them. The state has also excelled in its efforts to boost women entrepreneurs through its Self Help Group (SHG) programme, disbursing Rs 40,000 crore worth of loans to 600,000 such groups in the past five years alone. Many of these women now earn incomes for their families and are emerging as leaders in their own right. At the spanking new state bus terminal in Bhubaneswar, Debjani Das and her co-workers run a bakery, making, among other things, millet laddoos. Debjani, who is married to a police trainer and has three young children, said she was reluctant to join the group at first as she didn't know how to bake. But with the programme enabling her to go for training, she mastered the art and now earns Rs 10,000 a month, which she hopes to triple in the coming years.

WOOING WOMEN VOTERS Top, Dharmendra Pradhan canvasses in Sambalpur, May 14; Pandian obliges a supporter with a selfie at Chilika, May 18

With PM Modi gaining in popularity in Odisha and to counter the growing influence of the BJP, Naveen has also flanked central programmes with innovative state welfare schemes that strive to do one better. So, in the health sector, apart from revamping all tertiary and secondary care government hospitals, which includes providing them equipment and medicines, Naveen launched the BSKY in 2018. Unlike the Centre's Ayushman Bharat scheme, which is based on insurance claims, under BSKY, each adult is given a card to avail of free treatment of up to Rs 5 lakh, with the state paying the amount directly to the hospital.

THE PANDIAN FACTOR

And if Modi and the BJP thought they could trumpet the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, Naveen has wooed the Hindutva vote in the state by revamping the *parikrama* (perimeter) around the famed Jagannath temple in Puri. In a major operation headed by Pandian, the 75-metre *parikrama* was first chalked out, the existing buildings and obstructions demolished, and the area transformed with comfortable walkways and beautiful gardens. Naveen inaugurated it just days before Modi performed the *pran pratishtha* ceremony at Ayodhya in January this year. The Odisha government's efforts, says Pandian, have also been secular. Apart from renovating the Jagannath shrine, the state government has also worked to improve the conditions of 12,393 other temples, 1,160 churches and 660 mosques in the state.

However, while the Jagannath makeover may have burnished Naveen's Hindu credentials, Modi's construction of the Ram temple is likely to supersede it as the more significant achievement, providing greater traction for the BJP. The party has also raked up the controversy over the *parikrama* project, ac-